Everybody Writes / Silent Solo

Thinking in writing before discussion

Use Everybody Writes or Silent Solo when students need to form their own response before discussion. Writing gives quieter students a prepared idea and makes initial thinking visible.

How to do it well

1 Set the cognitive prompt. Choose a question requiring a claim, explanation, comparison or decision that students have the knowledge to attempt.

2 Specify the product. State how much to write and the important feature, so preparation does not become an unbounded essay.

3 Protect independent time. Students write silently without seeing another response or a model answer.

4 Use the written thinking. Compare in pairs, sample responses or project a useful contrast while keeping listeners accountable.

5 Revise deliberately. Students improve their own response and identify the reason for a change, preserving the learning gained from discussion.

What this sounds like

“Write your own claim and one piece of evidence before speaking. Compare with your partner, then revise the explanation in a different colour and explain the change.”

Classroom example. Before debating a historical claim, every pupil writes a position and supporting evidence. Partners compare the reasoning, then pupils revise their own statement and explain the change. The written first attempt protects independent thought; the final revision captures what the discussion added instead of leaving the learning inside an unrecorded conversation.

Top tips that make the technique work

Keep the first write bounded. A claim, two reasons or a first decision is often enough to prepare discussion.

Protect silence. The purpose is individual generation before a partner’s response influences the starting idea.

Choose a prompt worth writing. A trivial question may not need this preparation; reasoning benefits more.

Use the writing afterwards. Ask students to compare, refine or explain their first response rather than abandon it.

Build read–write–discuss–revise. The final revision captures what the discussion added and makes changed thinking visible.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Require everyone to commit an initial idea.	Allowing partner discussion during the individual stage.
Connect writing to later talk and revision.	Asking for writing that never informs the next task.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

Barton — Turn and Talk | Barton Independent practice